

XP LOVIN'



■ Prevention is better than cure

Make sure you back up all your data before you attempt to change anything—this could save you a lot of time and hair later. Create a System Restore Point by going to **Start > Programs > Accessories > System Tools > System Restore**, click 'Create a restore point' and then click Next. Now, name the restore point, and the date and time will be automatically added. Finally, click Create. Also, remember to backup your registry. Go to **Start > Run**, type '**regedit**' and press [Enter]. Go to **My Computer > File > Export**, and select 'All' in the 'Export Range' area at the bottom, choose a directory and file name, and click Save.

■ Boot-up time

Use the Welcome screen for logging in, as it enables faster boot ups. Disable Fast User Switching, and if you have only one user account on

your PC, leave your password blank. Now you won't be asked for your password every time you boot, thus reducing your booting time.

If you have multiple accounts on your computer, go to **Start > Run**, type '**control userpasswords2**' and press [Enter]. Clear the checkbox that says 'Users must enter a username and password to use this computer'. Now, go to Advanced tab and click

Advanced. Click the Users folder, and right-click the 'HelpAssistant' account. Choose Properties, and make sure the 'User cannot change password', 'Password never expires' and 'Account is disabled' checkboxes are checked. This is necessary for security purposes.

■ Healthy hard drives

Go to Windows Explorer, right-click your hard drive and choose Properties. Clear the checkbox that says "Compress drive to save disk space". Also, clear 'Allow Indexing Service to index this disk for fast file searching'—this relates to the Indexing Service, which indexes your files to reduce the time needed to search the hard drive for a specific file. If you disable it, normal performance becomes better. In the subsequent dialog box choose 'Apply changes to [Drive letter]:\, subfolders and files' and click OK. This will improve the performance of your hard drive.

For optimum performance, it is necessary to ensure that your hard drives are error-free. For this, scan your hard drives and defragment them regularly. Right-click on your drive letter in Windows Explorer, go to Tools and click 'Run Now...' or 'Defragment Now'. You can also use Diskkeeper, which is faster and more powerful, to Defragment your drives.

To increase the per-

formance of the disk drives, press **[Windows] + [Pause / Break]** to bring up the System Properties dialog box. Click on Hardware, and then Device Manager. Now click the '+' sign next to Disk drives to expand it, and double-click the disk name to bring up the Properties box. Click on the Policies tab, and select 'Optimize for Performance', check the 'Enable Write Caching on the disk' checkbox and click OK. Now under 'IDE ATA/ATAPI Controllers', double-click on 'Primary IDE Channel', go to Advanced Settings and check 'DMA if Available'. Do this for all the IDE channels.

■ Looks or power?

Open the System Properties by pressing **[Windows] + [Pause/Break]**, go to the Advanced tab and click on the Settings button under Performance. Click 'Adjust for Best performance'—this turns off all the bells and whistles, sets the theme to classic Windows and improves performance tremendously, especially in low-end systems. Now, click on the Advanced tab and click Change in the Virtual memory area. For optimum performance of your computer, it is necessary to set the virtual memory size correctly, depending upon the amount of RAM installed. It's better to have a dedicated partition for the paging file, rather than using the system partition. Make sure that Virtual Memory is around 1.5 times the RAM, or higher if you use



Decrease the bootup time by disabling password entry by users